



IN CONTEXT

The new face of witchcraft

In the 1940s, a wartime scandal highlighted how modern spiritualism had stirred up ancient fears about witchcraft. Helen Duncan was a Scottish medium who claimed to produce ectoplasm (a slimy substance that represented the spirits of the dead) from her mouth or nose. She was found guilty of making fraudulent claims to supernatural powers, and the ectoplasmic spirits were said to be made from cheesecloth, paper, chemicals, and faces cut from magazines. She became the last woman to be imprisoned under the British 1735 Witchcraft Act. However, some believed that the Act was not fit for purpose and her case probably helped speed its repeal in 1951.

Helen Duncan appears to be linked to her spirit guide, "Peggy."

Contacting the fallen

Public interest in making contact with lost loved ones rose sharply during the American Civil War (1861–1865). Childhood death, still common in this era, also fueled the growing popularity of the spiritualist movement. Abraham Lincoln's wife Mary Todd, for example, found comfort in spiritualism after the loss of her son.

By the late 1800s, the spiritualist movement had millions of adherents, but followers' motivations varied widely. Some saw spiritualism itself as a kind of religion, keen to promote the idea that it offered serious concrete proof of life after death. An element involving spiritual healing also developed, as exemplified by Andrew Jackson Davis's interest in mesmerism. However, there was also a different side to spiritualism. Its practice was typically organized as séances, overseen by mediums whose aim was apparently to enable their audiences to communicate with the spirits of the dead (see pp.228–229).

Private and public demonstrations by celebrity mediums proliferated across Europe and the US. For instance, Scottish-born Daniel Dunglas Home was much favored by the European upper classes

and even royalty. His talents included levitation: he was once reportedly seen floating out of one upper-floor window into another. Spiritualism enjoyed a celebrity following, too, with enthusiasts such as the Scottish writer Arthur Conan Doyle. Scientists, including William Crookes, a British chemist and President of the Royal Society, were also among its supporters. Crookes endorsed the work of British medium Florence Cook who during séances was said to materialize the spirit "Katie King" either in full or as a disembodied head.



▲ Ghost in the machine

Photographer William Mumler was famed for his images of people with "ghosts" in the background. Many of his clients found comfort in seeing lost loved ones appear as if by miracle.

► Uncanny transformations

This 1874 photograph convinced scientist William Crookes of medium Florence Cook's transformation into her alter ego "Katie King." When the similarity of Florence's and Katie's appearance was pointed out Crookes' belief was discredited.